Saniat Javid Sohrawardi

Preferred: John Sohrawardi

Postdoctoral Researcher
ESL Global Cybersecurity Institute
Rochester Institute of Technology
1 Lomb Memorial Drive, Rochester, NY

Phone: +1 (585) 465 6427
Email: john.sohrawardi@rit.edu
Web: nviable.me
ORCID: 0000-0002-4707-7035
Scholar: Google Scholar profile

Items with future dates are confirmed commitments.

Research Interests

Examines how journalists, intelligence analysts, and law enforcement make high-stakes verification decisions about synthetic and manipulated media, and how to design detection, provenance, and training tools that fit those decisions. This work combines mixed-methods human–computer interaction, explainable AI, and media forensics, and engages standards communities on how authenticity signals are communicated to people.

Education

2018–2025 Ph.D., Computing & Information Sciences, Rochester Institute of Technology

Dissertation: *DeFaking Deepfakes: Designing and Evaluating AI-Powered Digital Media Verification Tools for Journalists*

Adviser: Dr. Matthew Wright

Committee: Dr. Andrea Hickerson (University of Mississippi), Dr. Ersin Uzun, Dr. David Schwartz, Dr. Roshan Peiris

Defense Chair: Dr. Emi Moriuchi

2009–2014 B.Sc., Computer Science & Engineering, North South University, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Minor: Molecular Genetics

Research Appointments

2026–Present Young Researcher Associate, AI and Multimedia Authenticity Standards (AMAS) Collaboration, AI for Good, International Telecommunication Union (United Nations)

2025–Present Postdoctoral Researcher, ESL Global Cybersecurity Institute, Rochester Institute of Technology, Rochester, NY
Supervisor: Dr. Matthew Wright

2018–2025 Graduate Research Assistant, ESL Global Cybersecurity Institute, Rochester Institute of Technology, Rochester, NY
Adviser: Dr. Matthew Wright

Teaching

Instructor of Record

Spring 2025	CSEC 520/620 Cyberanalytics & Machine Learning	Rochester Institute of Technology

Guest Lectures

2023–2025	Introduction to AI: Media Manipulation and Deepfakes, CSE 440 (annual)	Michigan State University
2024	Deepfakes and Ethics, SWEN 559 (with Y. K. Wu)	Rochester Institute of Technology
2022	Deepfakes: Anarchy Loading, Software Engineering Ethics	Rochester Institute of Technology

Capstone and Research Mentorship

All projects at Rochester Institute of Technology.

2026–2027	Biometric Deepfake Detection	Capstone, DSCI 601
2026–2027	Mapping the Vocabulary of AI-Manipulated Media	Capstone, DSCI 601
Fall 2026	Privacy and Security Behaviors in AI Plugin and Skill Adoption	Capstone, CSEC 490
Fall 2026	Detection of Malformed Image Anomalies for Automated Dataset Curation	Capstone, CSEC 490
Summer–Fall 2026	Angler Project: Attribute-Aware Benchmarking and Interactive Performance Reporting for Deepfake and Synthetic Media Detection	Research assistant
2026	Motion Matching across Videos for Content Verification	Research assistant
2025	LIPINterpret: Advancing Explainable Deepfake Detection through Mouth Inconsistencies	Research assistant
2024–2025	Attribute-based Evaluation of Video AI-Manipulation Analysis Models	Capstone, DSCI 601
2024–2025	Unmasked: A Deep Dive into Analyzing Fairness and Robustness in Deepfake Detection	Capstone, DSCI 601
2023–2025	Deepfake Slayer: Deepfake Detection and Evaluation	Capstone, DSCI 601
2023–2025	Deepfake Trends Tracker	Capstone, DSCI 601

Selected Honours and Awards

2026	Fram Award, *Imagine RIT 2026*, for the exhibit “What Do You Mean by Fake? An Interactive Exploration of Synthetic Media”
2025	Third Prize, Poster Competition, *DFRWS USA 2025*, for “It’s About Time We Untangle Digital Media Forensics”
2022	Winner, Oral Presentation Category, *RIT Graduate Showcase 2022*, for “Dungeons & Deepfakes: A Role-Play Study to Understand Journalists’ Usage of AI-based Video Verification Tools”

Publications

Papers and posters that received awards are marked with ★.

Journal Articles and Book Chapters

[1] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, Y. K. Wu, & M. Wright. (2025). Verification AI in the Newsroom: A Cross-Cultural Study of Journalists' Use of Deepfake Detection Tools. Book chapter in *PROMISE–PROMoting AI's Safe usage for Elections*.

[2] A. Chintha, B. Thai, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, K. Bhatt, A. Hickerson, & M. Wright. (2020). Recurrent Convolutional Structures for Audio Spoof and Video Deepfake Detection. *IEEE Journal of Selected Topics in Signal Processing*, 14(5), 1024–1037.

Conferences

[1] Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, C. R. Gerstner, & M. Wright. (2025). Understanding and Empowering Intelligence Analysts: User-Centered Design for Deepfake Detection Tools. In *Proceedings of the ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)*.

[2] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, Y. K. Wu, A. Hickerson, & M. Wright. (2024). Dungeons & Deepfakes: Using Scenario-Based Role-Play to Study Journalists' Behavior Towards Using AI-Based Verification Tools for Video Content. In *Proceedings of the ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)*.

[3] A. Shrestha, A. Flood, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, M. N. Al-Ameen, & M. Wright. (2024). A First Look into Targeted Clickbait and its Countermeasures: The Power of Storytelling. In *Proceedings of the ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)*.

[4] A. Chintha, A. Rao, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, K. Bhatt, M. Wright, & R. Ptucha. (2020). Leveraging Edges and Optical Flow on Faces for Deepfake Detection. In *Proceedings of the IEEE International Joint Conference on Biometrics (IJCB)*.

[5] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, S. Seng, A. Chintha, B. Thai, A. Hickerson, R. Ptucha, & M. Wright. (2020). DeFaking Deepfakes: Understanding Journalists' Needs for Deepfake Detection. In *Proceedings of the Computation + Journalism Conference* and as a poster at the *Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS)*.

[6] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, S. Seng, A. Chintha, B. Thai, A. Hickerson, R. Ptucha, & M. Wright. (2019). Towards Robust Open-World Detection of Deepfakes. In *Proceedings of the ACM SIGSAC Conference on Computer and Communications Security (CCS)*.

[7] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, I. Azam, & S. Hosain. (2014). A Comparative Study of Text Classification Algorithms on User Submitted Bug Reports. In *Proceedings of the International Conference on Digital Information Management (ICDIM)*.

[8] I. Azam, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, H. S. Das, M. S. Alam, M. S. Alvy, & R. M. Rahman. (2013). Bibliomining North South University Library Data. In *Proceedings of the International Conference on Digital Information Management (ICDIM)*.

Under Review

[1] I. Bin Rofi, Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, M. Wright, & E. Uzun. Beyond the Accuracy Number: Auditing the Reasoning, Definitions, and Cues Behind Human Deepfake Detection. Submitted to *ACM CHI 2027*.

[2] Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, C. R. Gerstner, E. Uzun, & M. Wright. The Visual Media Forensics Ontology: A Common Language for Technique Description and Discovery. Submitted to *ACM CHI 2027*.

Posters

[1] I. Bin Rofi, Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, M. Wright, & E. Uzun. (2026). The Story They Tell Themselves. Poster at the *Human Computer Interaction Consortium (HCIC)*.

[2] I. Bin Rofi, Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, & E. Uzun. (2026). We Are Quite Bad at This! Poster at the *USENIX Security Symposium*.

[3] Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, E. Uzun, & M. Wright. (2026). The Techniques Are Ready. Is the Vocabulary? Poster at the *USENIX Security Symposium* and the *Human Computer Interaction Consortium (HCIC)*.

[4] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2025). It's About Time We Untangle Digital Media Forensics. Poster at *DFRWS USA 2025*, Chicago, IL. ★ Third Prize, Poster Competition.

[5] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, Y. K. Wu, A. Hickerson, & M. Wright. (2023). Dungeons & Deepfakes: A Role-Play Study to Understand Journalists' Usage of AI-based Verification Tools for Information with Video Content. Poster at *Great Lakes Security Day (GLSD)*. Also presented at the *Western New York Image and Signal Processing Workshop (WNYISPW)* and the *RIT AI Summit*, 2022.

[6] Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, & M. Wright. (2023). Exploring User-Friendly Explanations for Deepfake Detection. Poster at *Great Lakes Security Day (GLSD)* and the *Upstate New York Statistics Conference (UP-STAT)*. Also presented at the *RIT AI Summit*, 2022.

[7] B. Gernon, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, & M. Wright. (2023). Deepfake Bias: Analysis and Balanced Dataset Generation. Poster at *Great Lakes Security Day (GLSD)* and the *Upstate New York Statistics Conference (UP-STAT)*. Also presented at the *RIT AI Summit*, 2022.

[8] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, A. Chintha, B. Thai, S. Seng, A. Hickerson, R. Ptucha, & M. Wright. (2020). DeFaking Deepfakes: Understanding Journalists' Needs for Deepfake Detection. Poster at the *Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS)*.

Invited Talks and Briefings

[1] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2026). STOP&SCAN. Presentation to the *JPEG Trust* group, JPEG Committee, 28 October 2026.

[2] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2026). STOP&SCAN. Presentation to the *International Press Telecommunications Council (IPTC)*, 20 October 2026.

[3] **S. J. Sohrawardi** & Y. K. Wu. (2024). DeFake Project Overview. *ClaimBuster Ideation Workshop* (virtual).

[4] **S. J. Sohrawardi** & Y. K. Wu. (2024). Deepfakes Demystified: Empowering Law Enforcement in the Digital Age. Workshop at the *Law Enforcement & Emergency Services Video Association International (LEVA)* conference, Indianapolis, IN.

[5] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2024). Introduction to the VARUNA Project for Digital Media Forensics. *Scientific Working Group on Digital Evidence (SWGDE)* Workgroup Meeting.

[6] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2024). A Journey Through the Deepfake Landscape: Unmasking Threats and Building Defenses. *International Association of Chiefs of Police (IACP) Technology Conference* and *Canadian Institute's 2nd Annual Police Tech Conference & Expo*.

[7] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2024). Digital Media Forensics Ontology. *Semantic Forensics (SemaFor) Research Workgroup*, Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA).

[8] Y. K. Wu, **S. J. Sohrawardi**, & M. Wright. (2024). Digital Media Forensics Ontology. *Semantic Forensics (SemaFor) PI Meeting*, Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), Arlington, VA. Presented to digital forensics practitioners, vendors, and researchers.

[9] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2023). DeFaking Deepfakes. *RIT President's Roundtable*, Rochester, NY.

[10] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2023). DeFaking Deepfakes. *Global Collegiate Penetration Testing Competition (CPTC)*.

[11] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2022). We DeFake Deepfakes for Lunch. Seminar, *University of South Carolina*.

[12] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2022). Deepfakes: Crime and Solutions. *University of South Carolina School of Law, LegalTech Seminar on Deepfakes*.

[13] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2021). DeFake Project. *CyberVSR Seminar on Adversarial Machine Learning*.

Panels

[1] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2026). Beyond Data Dashboards: Information Validation and Interpretation. Panel on Deepfakes and Facial Recognition Technology, Oxford, MS.

[2] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2022). Understanding Deepfakes and their Detection. *RIT Grand Challenges Cybersecurity Panel*.

Contributed Talks

[1] **S. J. Sohrawardi**, Y. K. Wu, A. Hickerson, & M. Wright. (2023). Building a More Explainable Analyst-Centered Deepfake Detection Tool. *Laboratory for Analytic Sciences (LAS) Research Symposium*. [blog]

[2] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2023). DeFake: Developing a Usable Tool for Deepfake Awareness and Identification. *Human Computer Interaction Consortium (HCIC)*.

Exhibits and Public Engagement

[1] **S. J. Sohrawardi** et al. (2026). What Do You Mean by Fake? An Interactive Exploration of Synthetic Media. Exhibit at *Imagine RIT 2026*. Winner, Fram Award.

[2] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2023). Racial Bias in Face Recognition and Deepfake Technology. *RIT Computing Organization for Multicultural Students (COMS)* Spring Workshops.

[3] **S. J. Sohrawardi**. (2021). Understanding Dangers of Deepfakes and their Detection. Seminar talk, *RIT Women in Computing (WiC)*.

Media Coverage

[1] Featured in "Revolutionizing Tech at Imagine RIT," *13WHAM News*, 2026. [link]

[2] Guest, *The Matias Experiment* podcast, The Human Zero Day series, Ep. 1155, "John Sohrawardi: Bridging AI and Humans in Deepfake Detection," July 2025. [link]

[3] Interviewed with M. Wright and Y. K. Wu for "Deepfakes: What to Know About AI Images and Videos," *CNET*, March 2025. [link]

Selected Research Projects

DeFake Project	Founder and lead of a multi-institution initiative (~18 researchers, 4 universities) building usable deepfake detection tools for journalists and analysts.
STOP&SCAN	Lead developer of a public framework for judging the trustworthiness of online media, with the ITU AMAS Collaboration.
Dungeons & Deepfakes	Scenario-based role-play method for studying and training journalists' use of AI verification tools (US and Bangladesh).
Visual Media Forensics Ontology	Shared vocabulary of visual media forensics techniques, refined with intelligence analysts and domain experts.
BaitBuster 2.0	Contributor to clickbait detection and storytelling-based countermeasures for targeted clickbait.

Software, Datasets, and Tools

- **DeFake**, deepfake detection platform with interpretable analysis for journalists and analysts. defake.app
- **STOP&SCAN**, public companion site for the trustworthiness-evaluation framework. stopandscan.org

Grants

Received

- 2024–2027. *ReDDDoT Phase 2: VARUNA: A User-Centered All-in-One Media Forensics Platform*, National Science Foundation. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2024–2026. *Usable Tools for Deepfake Identification and Mitigation*, Omidyar Network. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2023–2025. *Building an Analyst-Centered Deepfake Detection Tool*, U.S. Department of Defense. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2021–2024. *Collaborative Research: SaTC: CORE: Small: DeFake: Deploying a Tool for Robust Deepfake Detection*, National Science Foundation. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2020–2022. *DeFake Detection Tool*, Knight Foundation. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2019–2021. *Robustly Detecting Deep Fakes*, The Miami Foundation. Co-wrote proposal.

Pending

- 2026. *Trustworthy Agentic Media Forensics*, SaTC 2.0: RES, National Science Foundation. Senior personnel; co-wrote proposal.

Submitted, Not Funded

- 2026. *Designing Unified Human-Centered Provenance Interfaces for Digital Media*, Microsoft Research Fellowship. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2026. *Cross-Platform Threat Intel for AI-Enabled Fraud: Intent-Aware Detection and Evasion Mapping*, Amazon Cybersecurity Research and Anti-Abuse Technologies. Co-wrote proposal.

- 2025. *Dungeons & Deepfakes: A Novel Role-Playing Methodology for Improving AI Literacy and Verification Skills in Journalism*, Google Academic Research Awards. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2025. *Designing Effective Communication for Signaling Synthetic Media on Video-Sharing Platforms*, Google Academic Research Awards. Co-wrote proposal.
- 2023. *Dungeons & Deepfakes in Europe: Bringing Synthetic Media Detection to Newsrooms*, Google Academic Research Awards. Co-wrote proposal.

Professional Service

Peer Review

- Reviewer, ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI), 2023–2026.
- Reviewer, International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM), 2024–2026.
- Poster Jury, Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS), 2023–2026.

Organizing

- Organizer, "Beyond the Provenance Pin" workshop, proposal submitted to ACM CHI 2027.
- Internet Arrangements Committee, Privacy Enhancing Technologies Symposium (PETS), 2021.
- Organizing Committee, Great Lakes Security Day (GLSD), 2021.

Fact-Checking Partnerships

- Contributing analyst, Deepfake Analysis Unit (DAU), Misinformation Combat Alliance (India), through a working partnership with the DeFake Project, 2024–present. Provide forensic analysis for published fact-checks; named and quoted in DAU reports.

Standards and Policy

- Young Researcher Associate, ITU AI for Good AI and Multimedia Authenticity Standards (AMAS) Collaboration, 2026–present.
- Member, Scientific Working Group on Digital Evidence (SWGDE); founding member of its Ad-hoc AI Committee, 2024–present.

Industry Experience

2017–2018	Senior Software Developer, Boomerang Digital, Dhaka, Bangladesh
2016–2017	Software Engineer, Chaldal Ltd., Dhaka, Bangladesh
2014–2016	Senior Web Developer, Boomerang Digital, Dhaka, Bangladesh

Memberships

- Association for Computing Machinery (ACM), 2024–present
- AI Risk and Vulnerability Alliance (ARVA), 2023–present
- IEEE Biometrics Council, 2022–present

- Content Authenticity Initiative (CAI), 2021–present

Languages

English, Russian, and Bengali (fluent); Ukrainian and Hindi (intermediate).

References

Dr. Matthew Wright	**Dr. Ersin Uzun**	**Dr. Andrea Hickerson**
Professor, Department of Cybersecurity	Executive Director, ESL Global Cybersecurity Institute	Dean, School of Journalism and New Media
Rochester Institute of Technology	Rochester Institute of Technology	University of Mississippi
EMAIL	ersin.uzun@rit.edu	EMAIL
Ph.D. adviser	Dissertation committee	Dissertation committee